

Guidelines for Writing a Bachelor's Thesis (BSc)

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1. Legal Framework

- *Fachhochschulgesetz des Kantons Zürich* (FaHG, LS 414.10)
(Canton of Zurich Act on Universities of Applied Sciences)
- *Rahmenprüfungsordnung für Bachelor- und Masterstudiengänge an der ZHAW Zürcher Hochschule für Angewandte Wissenschaften* (RPO, LS 414.252.3)
(General Exam Regulations for BSc and MSc Programs at ZHAW Zurich University of Applied Sciences)
- *Studienordnung für die Bachelorstudiengänge Angewandtes Recht, Betriebsökonomie, International Management, Wirtschaftsinformatik und Wirtschaftsrecht an der ZHAW Zürcher Hochschule für Angewandte Wissenschaften* (LS 414.253.811)
(Academic Regulations for the BSc Programs in Applied Law, Business Administration, International Management, Business Information Technology, and Business Law at ZHAW Zurich University of Applied Sciences)
- *Weisung Lehre ZHAW School of Management and Law* (SML)
(Directive Concerning Academic Study at the ZHAW School of Management and Law (SML))
- *Richtlinie Verwendung generativer KI-Systeme bei Leistungsnachweisen*
(Guidelines Concerning the Use of Generative AI Systems in Performance Assessment Tasks)

The legal framework of the “Guidelines for Writing a Bachelor’s Thesis” (“Guidelines”) consists of the latest versions of the above-mentioned documents.

2. Scope

The Guidelines apply to all BSc programs offered at the ZHAW School of Management and Law (SML).

3. Purpose

The Guidelines regulate all formal and organizational aspects of writing a Bachelor's thesis (“Thesis”) in the degree programs described in Section 2 above.

4. Complementary Documents

- *Richtlinie Masterarbeit (MSc)* (Guidelines for Writing a Master's Thesis (MSc))
- *Richtlinie Masterarbeit (MAS / EMBA)* (Guidelines for Writing a Master's Thesis (MAS / EMBA))

5. Thesis Aims

5.1 Professional Competence

The Thesis enables students to reproduce, explain, apply, analyze, synthesize, and systematically evaluate program content of theoretical and practical relevance accurately, at an appropriate level, and in a manner that is appropriate in scope and depth as well as topicality.

5.2 Methodological Competence

- Problem-solving and critical thinking: In the context of the Thesis, students can analyze an issue systematically and embed it in a theoretical context. They deduce potential solutions which they evaluate critically and in detail before proposing a well-reasoned solution. Students make their position clear within the context of their topic area.
- Scientific methodology: Students choose an appropriate method determined by their research questions and justify their decision. They employ their methodology in an effective manner and driven by their research questions. They recognize the limitations of their methodology and discuss these in the Thesis.
- Work methods, techniques, and procedures: Students can select, apply, and evaluate both general and specific work methods, techniques, and procedures based on their research questions. They understand the basic principles of academic writing (citation, dealing with sources, etc.) and apply them correctly.
- Information literacy: In their search of the literature, students focus on information that is topical, relevant, and helps them answer their research questions. They document the sources from which they draw their information, taking account of ethical and legal requirements and respect for intellectual property rights.
- Creativity and innovation: Students can conceive and implement creative and innovative ideas and solutions that help them answer their research questions. They design new concepts suitable for practical application in general or for individual organizations.

5.3 Social Competence

Written communication: Students write clearly, concisely, and effectively. Their statements are appropriate in the context of a Bachelor's thesis and their contribution in terms of content is clearly recognizable. The text is well-structured and the arguments are profound and compelling. There are few language errors (spelling, punctuation, grammar, style).

5.4 Self-Competence

Self-management and self-reflection: While working on the Thesis, students are able to plan their learning and work processes and organize meaningfully. They set appropriate targets for their learning and work processes and are able to pursue and reflect on them.

6. Types of Thesis

The Thesis can only be written by an individual student. Bachelor's thesis written as part of the Moot Court are exempt from this rule.¹

7. Topic Area

The content of the Thesis must relate to the student's degree program and specialization. Exceptions require the approval of the head of the degree program ("Program Head").

8. Thesis Supervisors

Bachelor's thesis can be supervised by academic assistants, teaching and research staff and professors at the ZHAW, provided the supervisor has at least a consecutive Master's degree or

¹ The formal requirements of the competition take precedence over this Guidelines.

an equivalent qualification (e.g. university diploma). As a rule, supervisors teach in the relevant subject area. For an external lecturer or a guest lecturer to act as Supervisor, he or she has to teach in the student's degree program and have the qualifications specified. Furthermore, the organizational unit in question must have written permission from the Program Head.

A student is not entitled to be assigned to a specific supervisor.

9. Topic Assignment

9.1 Topic Submission

Students can - within the time period specified by the Program Head - submit their own topic suggestions, which must include the details listed below. Topic suggestions submitted by students may be rejected.

Supervisors develop topic suggestions that fall within their discipline. They provide the following details:

- Topic, issue, working title
- Specific aim or detailed assignment
- Guidelines for action
- Details of external partner, if any.²

Supervisors can simultaneously offer topics for the degree programs in Applied Law, Business Administration, Business Law, Business Information Technology, and International Management.

External partners can also make topic suggestions to the Program Head or to an instructor, which must contain the details listed above. The topics are reviewed by the Program Head or the instructors to confirm whether or not they meet the requirements for a Bachelor's thesis. If a topic meets the requirements, the Program Head or Supervisor uploads it to MoLeNa.

9.2 Finalization of Topic

The topic suggestions are discussed with the Program Head. He or she can reject a topic deemed to be unsuitable; a reason for the decision needs to be provided. Approved topic suggestions are assigned directly to the students who have submitted them. The topics are uploaded to the MoLeNa platform, where all students have enough time to review them simultaneously.

After the available topics have all been uploaded, individual supervisors and students meet within a set period of time to discuss them. The final assignment of topics to students takes place via MoLeNa. Students are not entitled to be assigned a specific topic.

Students who have not chosen a topic within the set time period will be assigned a topic that is still available and has not yet been assigned. The Program Head will ensure that a sufficient number of thesis topics is available to be assigned to students.

Collaboration with an external partner can be regulated in an agreement.

² External partners are usually employers or clients.

9.3 Supervision

The Supervisor has a consulting role. He or she is not permitted to contribute towards a student's findings or results, or to correct or revise any text in the Thesis. No other support is given to students on methodological or technical matters.

The Supervisor must not be assigned more than eight students. Exceptions may be granted by the Program Head in consultation with the Supervisor's line manager.

A student may start to do preliminary work before the period reserved for writing the Thesis. However, Supervisors must not make such preliminary work compulsory.

The Supervisor's performance is evaluated by the student. This evaluation must take place within a set period of time and is stored on MoLeNa.³

10. Preliminary and Interim Meetings, Thesis Proposal

A preliminary meeting takes place at the beginning of the period reserved for writing the Thesis. During this meeting, the Supervisor confirms the topic details and the research questions with his or her students.

At the first interim meeting (approx. four weeks into the period reserved for writing the Thesis), the student must submit a thesis proposal ("*Disposition*") to the Supervisor which sets out how the Thesis will be organized.

Unless the Thesis has a legal topic, the thesis proposal outlines the issue to be explored (research question) as well as the aims and structure of the Thesis. The thesis proposal provides a content overview (Chapter 1) as well as information about the methodology, practical relevance, and theoretical framework.

If the Thesis has a legal topic, the thesis proposal outlines the issue to be explored (research question), the practical relevance of the Thesis (if applicable) as well as its aims, approach to be taken, and structure. A thesis proposal may also consist of a detailed table of contents.

Students must upload their thesis proposals to MoLeNa; they must be approved and evaluated by the Supervisor. Thesis proposals are either accepted ("*angenommen*") or rejected ("*abgelehnt*"). If a thesis proposal fails to outline the project clearly enough, it must be revised and resubmitted within a time period agreed with the Supervisor.

A second interim meeting is held after two-thirds of the period reserved for writing the Thesis have passed. The purpose of this interim meeting is to review the student's progress and discuss any final changes that may be necessary. Further interim meetings may be scheduled, if required.

The preliminary and interim meetings must be attended by the Supervisor and the students. If there is an external partner, his or her attendance is advisable. If the external partner cannot attend these meetings, the Supervisor must ensure that he or she is kept up to date (flow of information).

The student must minute the first and the second interim meeting. These reports must be uploaded to MoLeNa and are accepted or rejected by the Supervisor via the tool.

³ The supervisor can only view the evaluation results after the evaluation grid has been submitted.

11. Formal Matters

11.1 Organization

The Thesis must be organized in accordance with the usual standards of academic writing.

11.2 Thesis Structure

- Cover page
- Management summary (2,600 – 3,150 characters)
- Table of contents
- Other lists or directories (tables, illustrations, abbreviations, formulas, etc.), if required/requested
- Reference list (or list of sources (*Quellenverzeichnis*)) (for students of Business Law)
- Introduction (issue to be explored (topic), research question, limitations, relevance for the subject area, organization, focus areas, etc.)
- Main body (hypothesis, if any, analysis, and results)
- Final part (discussion and conclusions)
- Reference list (or list of sources (*Quellenverzeichnis*)) (for students of Business Administration)
- Other appendices, if applicable

If the Thesis is written in English, the following sections are recommended:

Cover page

- Management summary (2,600 – 3,150 characters)
- Table of contents
- Lists of tables and figures (as required/requested)
- Introduction
- Theoretical framework (= literature review and methodology)
- Results (= findings and discussion of findings)
- Conclusion
- Reference list
- Appendices (if necessary)

11.3 Confidentiality Agreement

If the Thesis is produced in collaboration with an external partner, the student and the Supervisor must sign a confidentiality agreement⁴. This ensures that any information supplied by external partners in the context of the Thesis is kept confidential. The student must provide the external partner with a copy of the signed confidentiality agreement.

⁴ Obtainable via the SML Intranet

11.4 Formal Guidelines and Volume

The Thesis must have a minimum of 40 and a maximum of 80 pages of text (A4 format, line spacing 1.5; font: Times New Roman 12 pts, left/right margin: 3 cm). The cover page, any lists and directories, and the appendix are excluded from this. Tables and other illustrations that have a different format must be attached separately. Exceptions can be granted by the Program Head.

The cover page must include the following information: "Bachelor's Thesis," thesis title and subtitle (if any), name of institution (ZHAW-SML; the logo must not be used), last name and first name of the student, student number, last name and first name of Supervisor, and submission date.

11.5 Submission

The Thesis and all relevant documents/data (e.g., transcripts, programming records, non-public resources, etc.) must be uploaded to MoLeNa by the submission deadline (as communicated to students). The Supervisor can ask students to submit a bound copy for assessment. If the Thesis has been commissioned by an external partner, an additional bound copy must be submitted to the Supervisor.

11.6 Citation Standard

All statements must be clearly identifiable. Information from reviewing the literature has to be identifiable in accordance with common standards.

12. Language

Bachelor's theses are usually written in German or English; in programs taught in English, they must be written in English. The language used for the Thesis must be agreed with the Supervisor. The Program Head can grant exceptions provided these are not in violation of the Academic Regulations.

13. Dates and Deadlines

Students have 14 weeks in which to write the Thesis. The specific due dates and time limits are set and communicated by the Program Head on an annual basis.

Requests for an extension of the submission deadline must be submitted via request form to Student Services within three working days (Mon-Sat) from the first day of the reason for the extension (date of email or postmark). Extensions are granted only if there is a valid reason (a medical condition or act of nature).

During the period reserved for writing the Thesis, the Thesis can be submitted at any time. The submission date is considered the date on which the Thesis is uploaded to MoLeNa.

If the Thesis is not submitted on time or if it is incomplete, the student will receive a grade of 1.0, and the Thesis will be considered as failed.

14. Intellectual Property

In accordance with § 22 (2) in conjunction with § 16 (1) lit. b of the Canton of Zurich Act on Universities of Applied Sciences, the university has the right to make use of works protected by copyright created by students while enrolled in a study program.

15. Utilization of the Thesis

15.1 Publication in ZHAWdigitalcollection

Provided the Thesis contains no sensitive information, the Supervisor, in consultation with the student, decides whether the Thesis may be made accessible through publication in ZHAWdigitalcollection. This decision is recorded on "MoLeNa" and can still be changed as long as the Thesis has not yet been submitted.

If the Thesis contains sensitive information, students must obtain the written consent of the written consent of the external partner.

15.2 Disclosure of the Thesis

Following consultation with the student, the Supervisor shall determine which parts of the Thesis, if necessary, in anonymized form, may be disclosed to involved parties (e.g. interviewees, external partners) or third parties.⁵

15.3 Utilization of the Thesis by Students

Any utilization of the Thesis by the student (e.g. Papers, Presentations, Start-ups, or publication of the Thesis) is subject to the approval of the Program Head upon request by the supervisor.

16. Expenses

If the Thesis was written with the involvement of an external partner, the student should be reimbursed by the partner for any expenses incurred. The external partner should, however, be notified in advance of any costs that may be claimed.

17. Ghostwriting, Editing, Proofreading, and Use of Artificial Intelligence

17.1 Support by Third Parties

Students are required to write the Thesis themselves without the assistance or support of a third party.

Third-party support includes the following:

Ghostwriting / Editing (<i>Fachlektorat</i>)	Another person writes a text for the student in question / Someone who is an expert in the field edits the Thesis.	The use of a ghostwriter or editor is completely inadmissible. It is irrelevant whether the person is known to the student personally or whether or not they receive payment. It is also irrelevant if the ghostwriter has stated that they have only provided a template or a draft.
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⁵ In the case of a Thesis conducted in collaboration with external partners, Clause 15.2 shall apply, unless otherwise stipulated in a contractual agreement.

The use of a proofreader (*Sprachkorrektorat*) is permitted. Proofreading involves the correction of grammatical and orthographical errors.

17.2 Use of Generative AI Systems

The use of generative AI systems must be discussed in advance with the Supervisor and disclosed in the Thesis. Generative AI systems are digital tools with technologies based on machine learning (artificial intelligence/AI).

Disclosure must include, at least:

- Whether output from generative AI systems is taken over in a form that is verbatim, paraphrased, or analogous, the subject-specific citation standard must be observed.
- If a student's own data or already generated output is (further) processed using generative AI systems, the tools used must be listed (summarized) in the Thesis, such as in a directory, stating the purpose of use.
- If generative AI systems are used for literature research, the usual requirements for citation accuracy and thoroughness of literature references must be observed.

18. Plagiarism

In writing the Thesis, students use cited sources only. The ZHAW guidelines "*Merkblatt zur Vermeidung von Plagiaten*" (Guidelines to Avoid Plagiarism) apply.

The university reserves the right to use electronic tools to check the Thesis for plagiarism.

19. Statement of Authorship

As part of the digital submission process (MoLeNa) for the Bachelor's Thesis, students must sign a form which confirms that they have written the Thesis themselves, without the help of third parties, and using only the sources cited. In addition, they confirm that the use of generative AI systems has been disclosed according to specifications.

20. Dishonesty

Plagiarism, the use of third-party support, and other inappropriate behavior in connection with citation and data are considered dishonest.

Cases of dishonesty will result in a grade of 1.0 for the Thesis as well as disciplinary proceedings.

If dishonesty only becomes known after the award of the Bachelor's degree, ZHAW may subsequently withdraw a title that has already been awarded.

21. Evaluation

Once the Thesis has been completed, the Supervisor will evaluate it on MoLeNa using the marking grid provided for the degree program in question. The evaluation must be submitted within the set time period. In cases involving an external partner, the evaluation has to be made in consultation with its representative.

The Supervisor must upload a copy of the evaluation grid to MoLeNa to enable the student to review it.⁶ In addition to completing the evaluation grid, the Supervisor will also write a summary

⁶ The evaluation grids can only be stored on MoLeNa after the students have evaluated the Supervisor.

evaluation of the Thesis (as an integral part of the evaluation grid). The Supervisor is required to discuss the Thesis with the student in person.

In order to award the grade 6.0 ("excellent"), a second opinion must be obtained. The Supervisor is responsible for identifying a qualified individual, who also supervises Bachelor's thesis, to provide this second opinion. The SML Teaching Compensation Guidelines (Merkblatt Vergütung Lehre) govern the additional remuneration for preparing the second opinion. The second opinion must be submitted within the deadlines for the correction of Bachelor's thesis as communicated by Student Services. If a student does not complete the Thesis or if he or she receives a grade that is below 4.0, the Thesis must be redone. A new topic must be chosen for this purpose.

22. Validity

The Guidelines are effective as of 1 August 2025.

23. Document Information

The original German version of the regulations can be found here:

[MB Merkblatt Bachelorarbeit BSc.pdf](#)

23.1 Metadata

Concerning	Details
Issued by	Head of Strategy, Quality & Projects
Decision authority	Dean
Classification	2.05.00 <i>Lehre Studium</i> (Degree Programs)
Scope of publication	Public

23.2 History

Version	Decided on	Decided by	Validity	Description of changes
1.0.0	01.12.2007	Dean		Original
2.9.0	12.06.2021	Dean	01.08.2021	Revision
2.9.1	-	-	-	Editorial changes GPM, 01.09.2022
3.0.0	10.05.2023	Dean	01.08.2023	Revised 1 and 11.4 New 17-20 Editorial changes
3.0.1	-	-	-	Editorial change
3.1.0	27.05.2024	Dean	01.08.2024	Revised 8 Editorial change
3.2.0	28.05.2025	Dean	01.08.2025	Revised 6, 14, 15 and 19 Editorial change